D'var Torah on Parshas Bo: Coming Together in Darkness

Introduction: The Richness of Sefer Shemos

Here we are going into Shabbos, Parshas Bo. Bo is one of those amazing Parshiyos, and the truth is that especially in the first portion of Sefer Shemos, we have so much to go through, so much action, so much activity, and so much to learn about what it means to be a Jew. It's very hard to get everything within the context and time frame, but I want to start with the most basic element, as so many commentators do as well: the name of the Parsha itself.

Bo: Come With Me

The word "Bo" appears at the beginning of our Parsha (Shemos 10:1): "ויאמר ה' אל משה בא אל פרעה," And Hashem said to Moshe: Come to Pharaoh.

Bo. The word itself is fascinating. We know that the letters Beis-Aleph have a numerical value of three, and there are three final makos, plagues, which happen in this week's Parsha. But beyond the numerology, there's something deeper happening with this word.

What is the difference between Hashem saying to Moshe "Bo el Paro" versus "Lech el Paro"? Bo means "come," come with, join with me. Lech means "go out," as we saw by Avraham Avinu (Bereishis 12:1): "לך לך מארצך," Go out from your land.

Lech represents self-sufficiency, being sent out for an individual task. Avraham was tested, sent out on his own journey. Chazal teach us that Hashem gives us avodas, tasks to do, and Hashem will never put on us more than we are capable of taking on. This doesn't mean He won't give us challenges we must face ourselves. We have to be able to step up, and Hashem will go with us.

But Bo is different. Bo is an invitation. Come with me. Let's do this together.

The Story of the Shliach

There's a famous story along these lines of a Shliach of Chabad who was sent somewhere and was afraid to go. The Rebbe asked him: "If you knew that I was going with you, would you go?" And the chassid said, "Of course, Rebbe, if the Rebbe's coming with me, then I would go with no questions asked." And the Rebbe said, "I'm going with you. Go, and I'm coming with you."

This is the idea of Parshas Bo. Bo el Paro. Come to Pharaoh, together.

The Fear of Tumah

We learn in Sifrei Kabbalah, particularly in the Zohar (Bo 34a), that in this situation there was actually a fear, a real hesitation on Moshe Rabbeinu's part to go into such a level of tumah, impurity. To go to the inner sanctums of Paro, where at this point his heart has been hardened by Hashem, and he's really just steeped in tumah and klipah.

The tumah of Egypt was not superficial. Egypt represented the 49th gate of impurity, the deepest level of spiritual contamination. For Moshe, the most pure of prophets, to enter Pharaoh's palace at this stage was to risk spiritual corruption.

And so the Sifrei teach: Bo, come with me. I will keep you pure. I will keep you safe from the levels of klipah, of the tumah of Paro.

Faith and Connection

There's so much to learn about being a Jew, being a Yid, from all of these concepts. Besides the strong inyanim, the strong ideas behind tahara and kedusha, purity and holiness, there's also the concept of being ma'amin b'Hashem, having faith with Hashem and understanding His actions, what becomes right versus wrong.

Moshe does not want to become tamei. He doesn't want to separate himself from Hashem. There's supposed to be a yichud, a unity, between Moshe Rabbeinu and Hashem, between us as Klal Yisrael and Hashem. And tumah is one of those things that breaks us apart. It separates us.

The Gemara in Chagigah (27a) teaches: "דברי תורה אינן מקבלין טומאה," Words of Torah cannot receive impurity. But the person speaking them can. This is Moshe's concern.

The idea of an avera, a sin, separates us. Death separates us because we're supposed to be living a life of kedusha. Moshe Rabbeinu knew this.

And so what did Hashem say? Hashem said, "I'm coming with you. Don't worry, this is not going to separate you from me. This is going to bring us together. We're doing this together. You put your right foot down and I will put down mine as well. You put your left foot down and I will put mine down as well. Step by step, action by action, moment by moment."

Now we're going into the hard times, Hashem says, now we do it together. You did your hishtadlus, your effort, now I have your back, and we're going to do this.

So much importance about being a Yid, about being a Jew, understanding that we are connected with Hashem every step of the way and in every single way.

The Power of Three

Other things that come up within this week's Parsha are so important, not just here but elsewhere. I mentioned the concept of the number three. Three from the name of the Parsha, Bo, Beis-Aleph equals three.

But if we look at the background, what does Moshe Rabbeinu say to Paro when he's trying to take us out? He says (Shemos 3:18): "דרך שלשת ימים נלך במדבר," A journey of three days we shall go in the wilderness, to bring korbanos.

The number three. We also know that in this week's Parsha, we have the last three plagues: locusts, darkness, and the firstborn. There's an opinion that says by Makkas Choshech, the plague of darkness, that there were three days followed by another three days, different levels of darkness.

And so we see this concept of three over and over again. The Avos are three: Avraham, Yitzchak, Yaakov. The Torah itself is divided into three parts: Torah, Nevi'im, Kesuvim.

We also learn in halacha that three establishes a chazakah, a presumption of permanence. This concept is brought down throughout Shas. The Gemara in Bava Metzia (106b) discusses how three times creates a pattern, a habit, something strengthened within you. There's a strength to the number three.

And in these times, we had to be strengthened. Why? Because also in this week's Parsha, we get into Pesach, we get into the korban Pesach, we have Yetzias Mitzrayim, we have the burning of the chametz and everything else. There's so much here that we could explore.

The Makkah of Choshech: Darkness and Light

But I want to focus on the concept of Choshech, darkness. Choshech is such an interesting thing.

On one side, you have a lot of fear that comes with choshech. My own children sometimes say, "Tatty, it's too dark for me, I'm scared of the dark." We have to remember, we have to remind them what's not to be scared of.

But by the makkah of choshech, we learn something profound. The Torah describes it (Shemos 10:22): "ויהי חשך אפלה בכל ארץ מצרים שלשת ימים," And there was thick darkness throughout the land of Egypt for three days. Then (Shemos 10:23): " לא ראו איש את אחיו ולא קמו איש מתחתיו שלשת ימים ולכל בני ישראל היה אור במושבתם," No man could see his brother, nor could anyone rise from his place for three days, but for all the Children of Israel there was light in their dwellings.

Rashi explains that there were actually two stages of darkness: three days where it was dark, and then three more days where the darkness was so thick that those who were standing remained standing, and those who were sitting remained sitting. No one could move.

During this time, the Jews who were not going to be coming out of Mitzrayim, those who were not going to be liberated, died. The Midrash (Shemos Rabbah 14:3) teaches that four-fifths of the Jewish people died during the plague of darkness. They had assimilated so deeply into Egyptian culture that they did not want to leave.

Why during darkness? Because darkness is stillness, it's calm, it's serenity. It's das, awareness, in a certain regard. While there was the confusion, the bilbul of choshech on one side, on the other side we also have the stillness and the awareness of what had to be done.

And Hashem was able to use this time as a way of tznius, modesty and concealment. We also know that tznius comes from concealment, from darkness. During this time, the Jews were able to bury their dead in a respectable way, not to have it where the Mitzrim could gloat and say, "Oh, look at this, we're not the only ones being punished, the Jews themselves are also being punished."

Hashem said, "No, these are My people. I'm going to show them dignity and respect," and they were able to utilize this concealment for holiness.

Finding Hashem in Darkness

There are a few other places where we see the concept of darkness coming up and the connection to Hashem.

In the Nesivos Shalom (Chelek Aleph, in the sections dealing with daas, awareness), it says that when a person is in the choshech, when they're in the darkness that is scary, where everything is hidden away from them that they cannot see, there we can actually reach out to Hashem. We can daven to Hashem, and Hashem will give us light.

The Nesivos Shalom is teaching us something crucial: darkness is not abandonment. Darkness is an opportunity for connection.

When we compare that to the choshech of Mitzrayim in the makkah, what do we learn? The Mitzrim, the ones who were mibbalbel, confused from all their avodah zarah, they didn't know what to do, where to go, and they had lost their hope. They didn't know how to daven. They didn't know how to ask for help. They were stuck and they were petrified in place by their fear.

Who had the light? The Jews. "ולכל בני ישראל היה אור במושבתם," For all the Children of Israel there was light in their dwellings (Shemos 10:23).

The Jews who had access to this higher level of das, even the ones who were still somewhat steeped in avodah zarah, were still able to see what was happening. Their eyes were opened up. They were able to reach out to Hashem and ask for guidance, ask for light, ask for spirituality and growth, and get to see what was happening.

The Thickness of Silence

The darkness was so thick, especially in the second set of three days, days four, five, and six, that one couldn't stand up or sit down. Everything was completely still, completely quiet.

What do we learn about silence? In Pirkei Avos (1:17), Shimon the son of Rabban Gamliel says: "כל ימי גדלתי בין החכמים ולא מצאתי לגוף טוב משתיקה," All my days I grew up among the wise, and I found nothing better for the body than silence.

Silence is what centers us. Silence is what grounds us. We can see and observe and hear our reality around us. We as Jews were able to harness silence and use it for that higher strength, for that better reality.

The Gemara in Megillah (18a) teaches: "תלמוד תורה כנגד כולם," Torah study is equivalent to all the mitzvos. But the Baal Shem Tov adds that sometimes silence is greater than speech, when that silence allows us to hear the voice of Hashem speaking to us.

Seeing in the Dark

The Jews during Makkas Choshech, Chazal tell us (Shemos Rabbah 14:3), were able to spy into the houses of the Mitzrim to know where all the wealth that they were promised was. The Torah had said (Shemos 3:22): "ושאלה אשה משכנתה ומגרת ביתה כלי כסף וכלי זהב ושמלת," Every woman shall request from her neighbor and from the dweller in her house silver vessels, gold vessels, and garments.

In this way, they were able to know where their gifts were going to be coming from. They knew what the world had for them. When the Mitzrim were shouting out in fear, not knowing what to do, the Jews, in a place of silence, in a place of calmness, in a place of reality, of das, they were able to learn. They were able to observe like wise people.

The Sfas Emes explains that this wasn't just practical preparation. It was spiritual vision. The Jews were able to see the truth of reality, that all the wealth of Egypt was really theirs, payment for centuries of slavery.

Personal Redemption Through Darkness

We see over and over again in so many different sources, the Sforno speaks about it, the Nesivos Shalom speaks about it, Rav Kook speaks about it: das, which is light, which is stillness, which is comfort, which is awareness, brings personal geulah, personal redemption. A personal zman geulas Mashiach also comes from this experience.

And what happened after Choshech? We're led on to Makkas Bechoros, the plague of the firstborn. We're led on to the Korban Pesach and to the Geulah, the redemption. Everything ties in here. All this reality, all these redemptions come about because, very simply, we are the Jewish people.

The progression is clear: darkness, stillness, awareness, and then action. First we must see clearly, then we can act decisively.

Hakoras HaTov: The Jewish Trait of Gratitude

And what does that mean? As we spoke about in last week's Parsha, there's also a sense and concept of hakoras hatov, gratitude, because gratitude is a Jewish trait. We are grateful for that which is given to us.

That opportunity of Choshech, of stillness, of calmness, we were able to take care of our own because Hashem gave us the ability to take care of our own in a tzniusdik, kosher, yashar, happy way. We were able to see the wealth that would be coming to us in the near future. We were able to see the redemption at hand. It was there, moments away.

And as Jews, we get to continue with that reflection of hakoras hatov to Hashem. How and why can we do that? Because when we move that next step forward, that next step in the right direction, we always need to remember where we're coming from.

Zecher L'Yetzias Mitzrayim

This is among the reasons, as described, why it is that in our tefilos, in Shema, everywhere: "זכר ליציאת מצרים," remembrance of the Exodus from Egypt. It's such an important thing.

As my sister says, as my cousins say, half-jokingly, "It's getting old." Why do we always have to think about Yetzias Mitzrayim?

Because Yetzias Mitzrayim was the start. We have to remember where we came from. It's the same reason why many people and nations around the world celebrate Mother's Day and Father's Day. They're remembering who they came from. Independence Day in America, in Israel, in Canada. Understanding and remembering where you came from: hakoras hatov, appreciation, being able to say thank you so much for what is given to me.

Masters of Time

Other things that come up in this week's Parsha: we learn more about zmanim, more about Rosh Chodesh, more about what it means to be masters of time, masters of reality.

The Torah says (Shemos 12:2): "החדש הזה לכם ראש חדשים," This month shall be for you the head of months. This is the first mitzvah given to Klal Yisrael as a nation.

Rashi explains: Hashem showed Moshe the new moon and said, "When the moon renews itself like this, you have a new month." This mitzvah of Kiddush HaChodesh, sanctifying the new month, is given to the Jewish people as a collective responsibility.

We as Jews have this amazing mitzvah, this power of Rosh Chodesh, and ensuring as well the concept of a leap year to make sure that we are in alignment. We make sure that Chodesh Aviv, the month of spring, remains in springtime (Shemos 13:4): "היום אתם יצאים בחדש האביב," Today you are going out in the month of springtime.

Because when we are in alignment, when everything is happening the way it's supposed to be and when it's supposed to be, that's when we become the shutafim, partners with Hashem in

the creation of the world. As we spoke about in Parshas Bereishis, as we spoke about by Noach and by Avraham Avinu, we are supposed to be partners, and Hashem wants us to have this beautiful partnership.

Reflection and Growth

Maybe we could take a moment by the Shabbos table and during the week and think:

On Partnership with Hashem:

- Where in my life do I feel like I'm going it alone, when really Hashem is saying "Bo," come with me?
- Do I trust that Hashem is with me in my challenges, or do I feel abandoned in the difficult times?

On Darkness and Stillness:

- Where am I being granted tznius, the gift of concealment and darkness, to work on myself privately?
- Am I able to find stillness and das, awareness, in the quiet moments, or do I fill them with noise?

On Hakoras HaTov:

- Where do I need to show more hakoras hatov to Hashem and to those around me?
- Am I regularly remembering where I came from, or am I taking my blessings for granted?

On Being Masters of Time:

- Do I control my time, or does my time control me?
- Am I living in alignment with Jewish time, with the rhythm of Shabbos and Yom Tov, or am I enslaved to the secular calendar?

Closing Thought

Parshas Bo teaches us that we don't walk alone. Hashem says, "Come with me." Even into the deepest darkness, even into the palace of Pharaoh himself, we go together.

The darkness isn't punishment; it's opportunity. It's a chance to see clearly, to bury our old selves with dignity, to recognize what we need to take with us into freedom.

And when we emerge from that darkness, we emerge as masters: masters of time, masters of our destiny, partners with Hashem in creation itself.

May we merit to hear Hashem's voice saying "Bo," come with me, and may we have the courage to go, knowing we never go alone.

Thank you so much, everyone who enjoys these, and those who don't enjoy these, thank you as well for listening. Have an amazing, amazing Shabbos.